10.6 Two Bodies Become One

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP III 2004, Question 11

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/04-s3-q11

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself Write down Newton's second law for each particle. In which direction does each force act?

STAGE 1 The separation

Ask yourself Which combination of the two equations involves only z?

STAGE 2 Energy for the separation

Ask yourself With $\ddot{z} = v\frac{\mathrm{d}v}{\mathrm{d}z}$, separate the variables and integrate. What are the initial values of z and $v = \dot{z}$?

STAGE 3 A surprisingly simple solution

Ask yourself The answer to show is $z^2 = 4t^2 - 2t + 1$. So look at $w = z^2$ instead of z. What is $\dot{w}^2$ in terms of w?

STAGE 4 The centre of mass

Ask yourself What equation does $2x_1 + x_2$ satisfy? Why is it the natural combination to look at?

Try this next

1 **Two masses on a string.** Try STEP III 2023, Question 9 (in OCR's download of the 2023 papers, www.ocr.org.uk/Images/707102-2023-past-papers.zip). It follows two particles joined by a string, using the centre of mass to separate the motion. Look for when one particle moves backwards.

2 **Attraction.** Repeat the question with an attractive force $\frac{2}{z^3}$. Show that z^2 is still a quadratic in t, and find when the particles collide.

3 **The hidden plane.** For the motion in the question, find the straight line in the plane whose distance from the origin is $z(t)$, and the angle $\theta(t)$ swept out. Check that $z^2\dot{\theta}$ is constant and that $(z^2\dot{\theta})^2 = 3$.

4 **Kepler's third law.** Two stars of masses m_1 and m_2 move in circles about their centre of mass, a distance a apart, under gravity. Show that the period T satisfies

$$T^2 = \frac{4\pi^2 a^3}{G(m_1+m_2)}.$$

Further reading

- **John Taylor, *Classical Mechanics*** (University Science Books), Chapter 8. The two-body problem, reduced mass and orbits.
- **Daniel Kleppner & Robert Kolenkow, *An Introduction to Mechanics*** (Cambridge University Press), Chapter 10, on central forces.
- **Francesco Calogero, *Classical Many-Body Problems Amenable to Exact Treatments*** (Springer). For the ambitious: the world of exactly solvable systems.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 10.6:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch10/two-body.html